A Street Corner for a Dime:
Don Rosa's Glasgow and the Chance of a Match

Mickaël Labarrère
Independent researcher mickael.labarrere [at] gmail.com ORCID 0009-0006-0822-3649

Version 1.5, 13 November 2026

Abstract

Don Rosa sets young Scrooge McDuck's first paid shoeshine at a Glasgow street corner in 1877, below a JAMAICA ST. plate. Does a real corner match the panels, and how often would such a match arise by chance? Every corner of a declared window at the foot of Jamaica Street is tested against the 1857–58 Ordnance Survey 1:500 plan and read in the 1877–78 Post Office directory. With the handedness of the inked view, 8 corners fit the drawn relations; one, Jamaica Street and Howard Street, also had a clothier on the corner and a spirit dealer across the side street. Yet the pair occurs at 3 of the window's 30 corners, including the later Paisley's corner: a survivor would carry it 62% of the time by chance, and the evidence raises the odds that Rosa drew a real corner only 1.2–1.5-fold.

Keywords: *chance baseline; comics geography; Don Rosa; Glasgow; historical GIS*

1 The question

In Don Rosa's *The Life and Times of Scrooge McDuck*, the ten-year-old Scrooge earns his first coin shining boots in Glasgow. In *The Last of the Clan McDuck* (Inducks D 91308, 1992), Scrooge's father sends a ditch-digger with filthy boots to be the boy's first customer, gives him an American dime to pay with, a coin that cannot be spent in Scotland, and hides with his two daughters to watch the lesson. The episode is older than Rosa: Vic Lockman's *The Invisible Intruder* (*Uncle Scrooge* 44, 1963, drawn by Carl Barks) made Scrooge a shoeshine boy, Carl Fallberg's *Getting That Healthy, Wealthy Feeling* (*Uncle Scrooge* 50, 1964, drawn by Tony Strobl) made shining shoes the source of his first dime, and Rosa recreated panels from both stories (Ottens, 2020a). Rosa's *Of Ducks, Dimes and Destinies* (D 91249, published in 1995) shows the same minutes from a bar across the street, where a visitor from the future sits at a table (Rosa, 2015; Inducks, n.d.). Rosa's commentary pairs the two views as "the same scene seen from two angles" (our translation of the French edition, Rosa, 2013, p. 25), calls the comparison a "challenge to science" and places the scene in Glasgow in 1877. He also drew a real street: in chapter 0, as the visitor drops the coin (ch. 0 p. 3; Table 1, H2), a plate reads JAMAICA ST. above a clothier's sign, PAISLEY'S, and Paisley's was a real outfitter at the foot of Jamaica Street (Canmore (Historic Environment Scotland), n.d.; Grace's Guide, n.d.; Ottens, 2020b). The question is whether a street corner of the Glasgow of 1877 matches what the panels show, how many do, and how often such a match would arise by chance.

Historical GIS combines town plans and directories into one description of a street (Gregory and Ell, 2007; Shaw, 1984; Cura et al., 2018), and the uncertainty of sources that do not share a date with the event has its own taxonomy (Plewe, 2002). The vantage point of a painting or an engraving can be recovered from the terrain (Frajer and Šimáček, 2019; Zohar and Shimshoni, 2021; Aubry et al., 2014; Olson, 2014); that a watcher sees both faces of a corner is a visibility condition in the sense of Benedikt (1979). Comics have been read geographically (Dittmer, 2010). Our object differs: a drawn scene, not a view from life, so the picture constrains the plan only through a handful of relations, and the search must be exhaustive over a bounded area rather than a fit to one candidate. We found no prior identification of the corner. The only published discussion we found places the story in and around Jamaica Street from the printed plate and argues that, because Jamaica Street had a tramline from 1872, the street where the visitor arrives cannot be Jamaica Street (Ottens, 2020b); that street is not the shoeshine corner.

Identifications of the real place behind a picture or a fiction usually argue from a match and rarely report how often such a match would arise by chance. The placing of Vermeer's *Little Street* from the Delft registers is a careful example (Grijzenhout, 2015); chance baselines are standard elsewhere, as for ley lines (Broadbent, 1980). Literary and narrative geography treats fictional settings both as places and as composites (Piatti et al., 2009; Hones, 2014; Saunders, 2010; Caquard, 2013), comics geographies read the space of the page in its own right (Dittmer, 2010; Peterle, 2017; Laurier, 2014), and readers' wish for a real place has its own literature (Reijnders, 2011). This paper offers a worked case of a placement reported with its own chance rate. It separates whether

Table 1: What the panels give, and how firmly. "Drawn": visible in the panel. "Told": stated in Rosa's commentary. "Read": the author's reading. "Adopted": taken from an earlier exploratory reading by a language model. "Not applied": reported as a sensitivity only. "Not met": no admissible watching point on the plan reproduces the reading. Ch. 0 is D 91249, ch. 1 is D 91308. An asterisk marks a provisional page or panel reference.

	Statement	Status	Where
H1	The scene is in Glasgow, in 1877.	drawn, told	ch. 1, pp. 1–7; Rosa's commentary, Rosa (2013, p. 25)
H2	A street plate, JAMAICA ST., and a shop sign, PAISLEY'S, appear in the sequence where the visitor drops the coin. The sign is on a flat frontage; no corner is in that view.	drawn	ch. 0 p. 3, lower-left panel
H3	The two stories present the same episode: Rosa pairs ch. 0 p. 15 panel 1* with ch. 1 p. 7 panel 6* (his numbering; in our count panel 6 is a hiding view). The corner views agree on the side of the boy and the direction the customer leaves. The pencil draft of ch. 1 p. 7 marks the corner panel "redrawn / rerun".	told; drawn	ch. 0 p. 15 panel 1*; ch. 1 p. 7 panels 4, 6; pencil p. 7 panel 5*
H4	The stand is at the foot of a clothes shop, against its windows, on one face of a corner building. A bar is across the street from that face; the customer goes there and the visitor watches from a table inside. Between the table and the shop the street has a cobbled roadway and a kerbed footway. The shop and bar names (SOU'S, FITCH in the French edition; PEACHY'S) differ between editions and match no 1877–78 occupant; they are not used as evidence.	drawn	ch. 0 p. 13* (bar); p. 14 panel 4*; p. 15 panels 1* and 3*
H5	In the inked corner view, the father and his daughters watch from across a roadway, on which a horse and cart pass, and see both faces of the corner. Looking at the corner, they have the stand's street on their right. In the view from the bar the corner edge is at the left of the shop front, which is the same handedness seen from across X.	drawn; side read	ch. 1 p. 7 panel 4; ch. 0 p. 14 panel 4*
H6	In the hiding views the watchers stand on a footway against a brick wall beside a quoined edge, their own building's corner, and look across a cobbled roadway at the boy on the far footway. Earlier versions read these views as drawing no street between them; the pencil draft, read the same way, has not been re-examined.	drawn; agrees with H5	ch. 1 p. 6 panel 6, p. 7 panel 6; pencil p. 6 panel 8*
H7	Up to version 1.4 the street crossed by the customer (X) was taken as narrower than the street watched across (Y), with w_Y/w_X between 1.5 and 3, a band adopted from a single earlier exploratory reading by a language model (ChatGPT). No panel shows both street widths cleanly.	adopted; not applied	ch. 0 p. 15 panel 1*; ch. 1 p. 7 panel 4
H8	The watchers are a few adult heights from the corner, four to six by the author's reading.	read; not met	ch. 1, pp. 6–7

the artist used a real corner of the window at all from which corner it would be, and it states which analytic choices were made after seeing the data (Gelman and Loken, 2014; Steegen et al., 2016).

Page numbers count from the first page of each story, and panels from left to right, then top to bottom; the book pages of the English and French editions are given in the data supplement (Rosa, 2015, 2012, 2013). Rosa's pencil layouts of chapter 1, pp. 6–7, circulated online with his copyright notice, are cited as the pencil draft (Rosa, 1992). References marked with an asterisk have not yet been checked against the printed page. No panel is reproduced.

2 What the panels tell us

A drawing is not a survey. What it fixes, what it suggests and what we add are kept apart in Table 1. *Handedness* is which side the side street leaves on when the watchers face the corner. Figure 1 reduces the three views to their geometry.

H5 gives the geometry: two streets meet at a corner A; the watchers stand on the frontage facing A across

Y, far enough along it towards X that face X of the corner block is in view as well as face Y. H4 gives two trades to look for, a clothes shop at A whose front is on face X, the face the bar looks at, and a drinking place on the block facing the stand across X. H4 and H5 also draw both streets as carriageways, with a cart on Y and a roadway and a footway on X; a lane can be neither. H2 gives a place to start, Paisley's, but not the answer: the sign hangs on a flat frontage with no corner in view, Paisley's is listed on Jamaica Street only from 1880–81, and its later corner at the Broomielaw fails the geometry, although in 1877–78 it already carried the pair of trades (Section 3). The handedness of H5 rests on the inked corner view, which the pencil draft marks as a redrawing and draws mirrored, and on ch. 0 p. 15 panel 1*; the view from the bar agrees with it. The results are given with and without it, the setting with handedness first. The hiding views (H6) show the same arrangement as H5, watchers beside a building across a roadway from the boy; they add no constraint the census does not already apply.

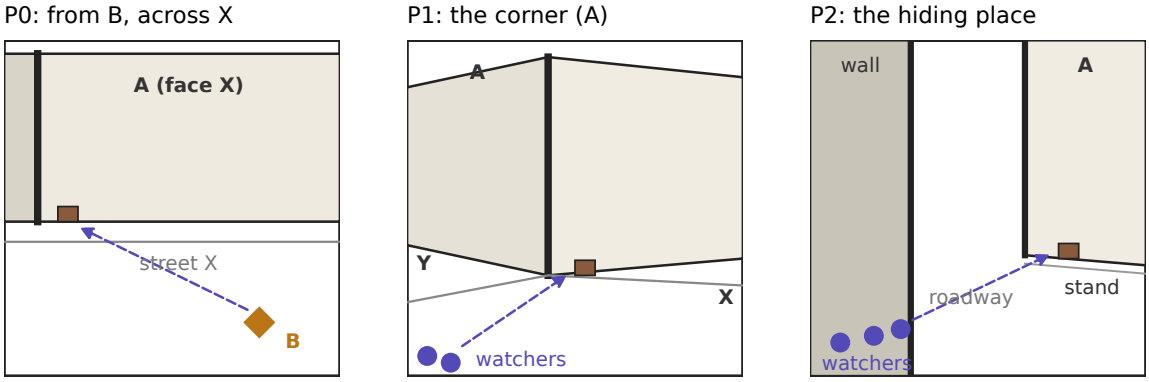


Figure 1: The three views reduced to their geometry: edges, faces, the stand, the watchers and their line of sight. No lettering, pose, prop or staging is taken from the drawings; schematic after D 91249 and D 91308, © Disney, and excluded from the licence of this paper. P0: from the licensed premises B across X, the X face of corner A with the stand at its foot (ch. 0 p. 14 panel 4*). P1: the inked corner view, both faces visible and the stand on the right-hand face (ch. 1 p. 7 panel 4). P2: the hiding view, the watchers against their own wall beside a corner edge, looking across a roadway at the stand (ch. 1 p. 6 panel 6, p. 7 panel 6).

3 What the archives tell us

Sources. The Ordnance Survey 1:500 town plan of Glasgow surveyed in 1857–58, in the georeferenced layer of the National Library of Scotland (Ordnance Survey, 1859): the nearest large-scale survey before 1877, which draws building lines, pends, closes and recesses; and the 1:500 plan of 1892–94, to see what had changed (Ordnance Survey, 1895). The Post Office Annual Glasgow Directory, the 1877–78 volume for the year of the story and fourteen others from 1860–61 to 1905–06 to follow particular addresses (Post Office, 1860–1906). Ottens's objection that Jamaica Street carried trams from 1872 (Ottens, 2020b) is not tested: rails or wires in the panels were not checked, and if present they would speak to Rosa's source rather than to 1877.

Problems of date. The sources do not share a year with the story (Plewe, 2002). The best plan predates it by twenty years and the next follows it by fifteen; the district was being rebuilt for the railways in the late 1870s (St Enoch station opened in October 1876, RailScot, n.d.; the Caledonian Railway, authorised in 1873, carried a viaduct across the Clyde into its Central station, opened in 1879, Tunnicliffe, 2026), so a feature drawn in 1857 is unattested for 1877 itself. The sign is later than the story. In the 1876–77 to 1879–80 volumes Peter Paisley is listed "of S.S. Clothing Co." on the south bank; 72 Jamaica Street is Abraham Rowand's, a clothier, in 1877–78 and Paisley's only in 1880–81 and 1881–82; later volumes place Paisley's at 80 and 96 Jamaica Street (1885–86), then at 82 to 96 Jamaica Street and 2–12 Broomielaw (1890–91), the Broomielaw corner. That corner was already a clothier's in 1877–78: James Thomson, "clothier and colonial outfitter", at 92–96 Jamaica Street and 2 Broomielaw, with John Barr, wine and spirit merchant, at 85–87 Jamaica Street across the street (street-section lines checked on the page image, trades from the general section in the OCR). Ottens reproduces an early twentieth-century view of Jamaica Street with Paisley's (Ottens, 2020b); a view of that kind is one plausible route for the sign, but whether it shows any of the corners below has not been checked.

Procedure. The census has five reproducible steps.

1. Declare the window: from Argyle Street to the Clyde and from Oswald Street to St Enoch Square, around the later Paisley's corner (Figure 2). It holds 30 building corners.

2. Enumerate every orientation of every corner (a choice of the street Y watched across, the other being X) and test those whose facing frontage is digitised: 46 orientations. 14 cannot be tested. For 8 of them the river quay or the approach to Glasgow Bridge lies across Y: there is no frontage there, so no watching point, and the inked corner view and the hiding views draw a building edge and a kerbed footway on the watchers' side (H5, H6). The facing frontage of the others has not been digitised (the north side of Argyle Street opposite Oswald Street, Fox Street, Wood Lane). The directory is read for every orientation, tested or not, and every corner enters the chance population.
3. Treat every point of the facing frontage, sampled every 0.5 m, as a possible watching point. The 62 openings recorded on the 1857 plan (pends, recesses, street mouths), the only watching points of version 1.4, are kept as a sensitivity and for the distances quoted below.
4. Apply the relations of H5: the watching point beyond the building line of face X ($d > 0$, where d is its offset along the axis of Y from the line through A perpendicular to Y, and D its distance to the corner), and the stand's face seen at 15° or more, the angle being taken as $\arctan(d/w_Y)$ with streets treated as perpendicular. The handedness of H5 (X on the watchers' right) is applied in one setting and dropped in the other. Orientations whose Y or X is a lane (Adam's Court Lane, 3.9 m wide on the 1857 plan) are excluded (H4, H5).
5. Read the 1877–78 directory for every orientation under a written codebook (data supplement): the trade of the corner premises, whether the clothier's own entry gives an address on X, as the shop must front X (H4), and the licensed premises on the block facing the stand across X.

The lane exclusion and the address on X were not part of a first census, which applied only the geometric relations of H5 and asked for a clothier anywhere in the corner premises. Both were added after that census returned a corner on a lane whose clothier fronts the other street (Section 4). The first coding is reported alongside the principal one throughout. Of the 46 orientations, 8 are on Adam's Court Lane. With handedness, 25 of the others have a watching point that sees both faces, 13 keep X on the right and 8 pass the angle, on 8 corners; without it, 14 corners remain. The geometry alone does not single out a corner. Watched across Jamaica Street, the later Paisley's corner fails: from no point of the frontage facing it does a watcher see both faces of the north-west corner of Jamaica Street and the Broomielaw. Watched across the Broomielaw, its watchers would stand on the quay or the bridge approach, outside the census.

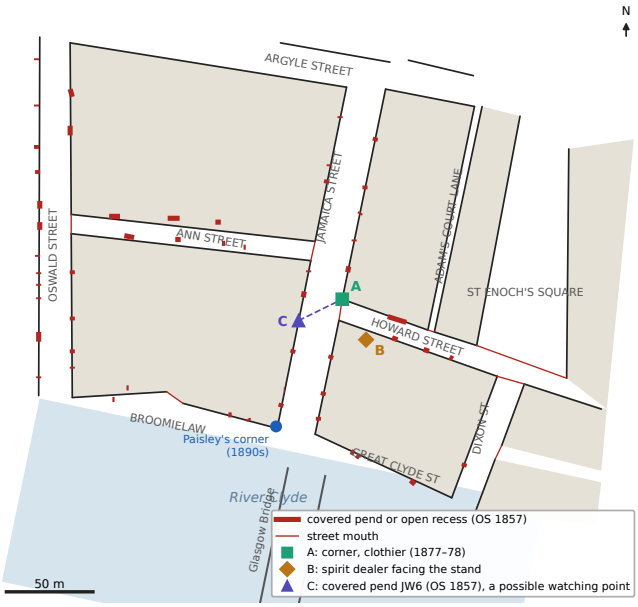


Figure 2: The window at the foot of Jamaica Street, redrawn, not reproduced as a facsimile, from the OS 1:500 plan surveyed 1857–58 (Ordnance Survey, 1859) (National Library of Scotland georeferenced layer, re-use stated as CC-BY (NLS), consulted 9 November 2026). Red marks are the 62 openings recorded in 1857. The blue point marks the later Paisley's corner at the Broomielaw. A is the surviving corner with both trades; B and C are the licensed premises and the pend of Section 4 at A.

4 Results

The surviving corners. Table 2 lists every orientation that passes the geometry in either setting, lanes included, with its nearest admissible watching point and the 1877–78 evidence for its trades. With handedness,

1 of the 8 corners has a clothier whose shop fronts the side street and licensed premises facing it across that street. At the north-east corner of Jamaica Street and Howard Street, Hugh Morrison, "clothier and Highland costume maker, 51 and 53 Jamaica street, and 1, 3, 5, 9 Howard st.", faced J. B. Turner, spirit dealer, at 6 Howard Street, across Howard Street; both lines were checked on the page images. Without handedness, 14 corners survive and a second one matches: Jamaica Street and Argyle Street SW watched across Argyle Street, where James Blackwood & Son, clothiers, at 2 Jamaica Street and 211 Argyle Street, faced Rutherford & Co., restaurateurs and wine and spirit merchants, at 9 and 11 Jamaica Street, across Jamaica Street, with Matthew Paxton, spirit merchant, also at 11; these lines were checked on the page images of the 1877–78 volume only. Jamaica and Argyle SE, with Simpson & Sons, clothiers, at the corner, matches only partially (a hotel or a grocer and wine merchant opposite). The other survivors have a named non-clothier at the corner, or premises that cannot be tied to the corner in the OCR (Dixon Street and Fox Street).

A corner that matched only in the first coding. A first census returned a second match with handedness: the south-east corner of Argyle Street and Adam's Court Lane, watched across Argyle Street, where the Argyle Street section reads "185 Donald, Jas. jun. clothier / Adam's Court Lane / 187 Fraser, A. spirit merchant" (OCR only). The panels contradict it twice. Its side street is a lane 3.9 m wide on the 1857 plan, where H4 draws a roadway and a footway. The directory lists Donald only at 185 Argyle Street, the street the watchers look across, whereas the stand is at the foot of the shop on the face the bar looks at: the Adam's Court Lane section names three other firms, and no general-section entry for him was found in the OCR. In the first coding, 10 corners survive with handedness and 2 of them match; without handedness, 17 and 3.

Table 2: Every orientation that passes the geometric relations with or without the handedness convention, ordered by the distance D from the corner to its nearest admissible watching point on the facing frontage. "Hand.": passes with the handedness convention. "1857": nearest admissible opening recorded on the 1857 plan. Then the 1877–78 directory evidence (Post Office, 1860–1906). Bold: clothier fronting X and licensed premises both attested. †: Y or X is a lane; excluded from the principal census, kept in the first coding. "On X: no": the clothier's only address is on Y. "Partial": a positional or trade near-match; "unknown": the premises could not be tied to the corner, or the OCR was silent. Rows other than Jamaica × Howard NE and Jamaica × Argyle SW (Argyle / Jamaica) were read in the OCR only. Generated from the data by the companion code.

Corner A (Y / X)	Hand.	D (m)	1857	At the corner, 1877–78	Facing the stand across X, 1877–78
Howard × St Enoch Sq. NE (Howard / StE)	no	11	HS-Dix	Reid Brothers, colliery and engineers' furnishers: no	not assessed: unknown
Howard × ACL NW† (Howard / ACL)	yes	12	HS3	Corson & Currie: no	M'Laughlin, Patrick: partial
Howard × ACL NE† (Howard / ACL)	no	12	HS1	Henderson, John: no	not assessed: unknown
Howard × St Enoch Sq. NW (Howard / StE)	yes	13	HS-Dix	Adam, James: no	Reid Brothers, colliery and engineers' furnishers: unknown
Dixon × Fox SE (Dixon / Fox)	no	16	–	not identified: unknown	not assessed: unknown
Jamaica × Argyle SE (Argyle / Jamaica)	yes	17	–	Simpson, R.: yes	Blair, Campbell: partial
Dixon × Fox NE (Dixon / Fox)	yes	17	DW1	not identified: unknown	not found in OCR: unknown
Argyle × ACL SE† (Argyle / ACL)	yes	19	–	Donald, Jas.: yes, on X: no	Fraser, A.: yes
Jamaica × Argyle SW (Argyle / Jamaica)	no	19	–	Blackwood, James: yes	Rutherford & Co.: yes
Ann × Oswald SE (Oswald / Ann)	no	19	OW5	Taylor & Ferguson: no	not assessed: unknown
Ann × Oswald NE (Oswald / Ann)	yes	19	OW7	Macfarlane, J. & J.: no	not assessed: unknown
Jamaica × Ann NW (Jamaica / Ann)	no	23	JE5	Blair, Campbell: no	not assessed: unknown
Jamaica × Howard NE (Jamaica / Howard)	yes	23	JW6	Morrison, Hugh: yes	Turner, J. B.: yes
Jamaica × Ann SW (Jamaica / Ann)	yes	23	JE4	Dryburgh, William: no	Blair, Campbell: partial
Jamaica × Howard SE (Jamaica / Howard)	no	24	JW5	Gordon, Robt.: no	not assessed: unknown
Howard × Dixon SE (Howard / Dixon)	yes	36	HN-ACL	Lorne Restaurant: no	Wilson, George: unknown
Argyle × St Enoch Sq. SE (Argyle / StE)	yes	70	–	Allan & Stewart: no	not assessed: unknown

The candidate in detail. The north-east building corner of Jamaica and Howard Streets is about 83 m in plan distance from the later Paisley's corner. Jamaica Street is measured as 22.9 m wide and Howard Street as 11.5 m. For a watcher on the west side of Jamaica Street looking at that corner, Howard Street leaves on

the right. The nearest admissible watching point on that frontage is 23 m from the corner (14 adult heights); the nearest opening recorded in 1857 is a covered passage 2.8 m wide (JW6), 17.1 m south of the corner along Jamaica Street and 27.9 m from its edge, leading to a small court that the directory index may name as "Smith's Court, 62 Jamaica street" (by number only). From it the stand's face would be seen at 37° in the model and 46° on the plan, where the two faces of the corner meet at about 98° (Figure 3). The sampled volumes list a clothier at 53 Jamaica Street in every sampled year from 1860–61 to 1895–96 (Morrison Brothers in 1860–61, Hugh Morrison to 1891–92, R. W. Forsyth from 1892–93) and a spirit dealer at 6 Howard Street, called West Howard Street in the trades list, from 1860–61 to 1895–96. The "P.H." marked on the 1892–94 plan about 19 m east of the south-east corner, along Howard Street, may be Turner's premises; the identification is not proved.

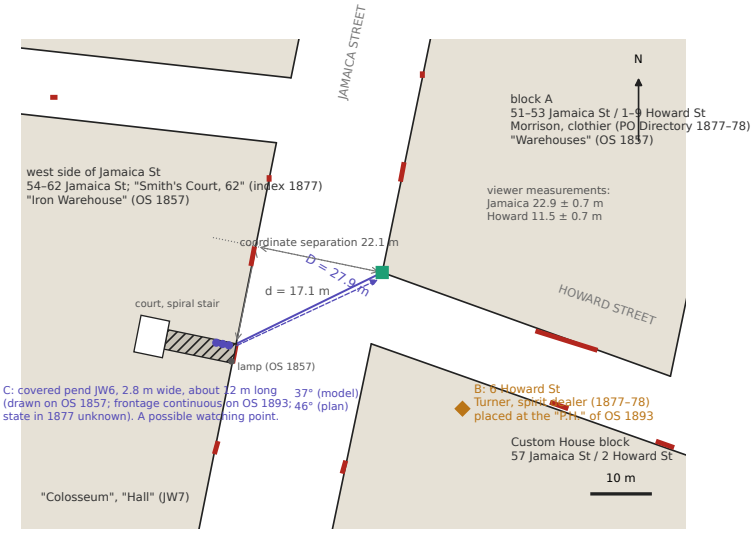


Figure 3: Jamaica Street and Howard Street at plan scale, redrawn, not reproduced as a facsimile, from the OS survey of 1857–58 (Ordnance Survey, 1859); National Library of Scotland georeferenced layer, CC-BY (NLS). A: north-east corner, Hugh Morrison, clothier, 1877–78. B: 6 Howard Street, J. B. Turner, spirit dealer, 1877–78, tentatively placed at the "P.H." of the 1892–94 plan. C: covered passage JW6, drawn in 1857; the angle at C is given as the census computes it, treating the streets as perpendicular, and as measured on the plan. The length of the passage and the court are schematic. Coordinates (WGS84, approximate): A 55.8572, −4.2571; C 55.8571, −4.2575.

Would such a match turn up by chance? Every corner of the window has at least one orientation with premises across X and could carry the pair; all 30 form the population. The pair occurs at 3 of them: Jamaica and Howard NE, Jamaica and Argyle SW, and the later Paisley's corner, watched across the Broomielaw, where James Thomson's shop on Jamaica Street faced John Barr's across it. If those matches were placed at random among the 30 corners, at least one of the 8 survivors would carry one 62% of the time (Table 3); without handedness, 86%; in the first coding, 82%. A match among the survivors is therefore more likely than not, even where the candidate is the only one. Two further questions remain. Let H0 be that the scene shows no real corner of the window, so that each survivor carries the pair at a rate r estimated from the corners that fail the geometry (Beta posterior, Jeffreys prior), and H1 that it shows one of the survivors, which carries the pair with probability q (the trades were drawn from the real corner and the directory records them). The Bayes factor of H1 against H0 lies between 1.2 and 1.5 for q from 0.5 to 1 (1.4 at $q = 0.8$; 1.2 with a uniform prior): in this setting the evidence raises the odds that Rosa drew a real corner of this window by a factor of 1.5 at most, "not worth more than a bare mention" on the usual scale (Kass and Raftery, 1995); across the 36 variants of the data supplement it lies between 0.4 and 1.7. If he did, the corner is Jamaica and Howard NE with probability 0.86 at $q = 0.8$; without handedness, Jamaica and Argyle SW shares that probability with it (0.44 each), and in the first coding Adam's Court Lane SE does (0.44 each). Even a real, faithfully drawn corner would come out as the single match only 39% of the time at $q = 0.8$. Restricted to the 8 corners of Jamaica Street, the street of the plate (H2), the chance is 82% and the Bayes factor about 1.1.

Sensitivity. Table 4 varies the geometric settings. On the openings recorded in 1857, with the first coding, the census gives the 7 corners that version 1.4 obtained without its width-ratio filter and the 5 of its published result with that filter; in both, Jamaica and Howard NE is the only one with both trades, as in version 1.4, which computed no chance figure. With the population of version 1.4 the chance is 66% without the filter and 52% with it (Bayes factor 1.4–1.9). With handedness, Jamaica and Howard NE is the only corner with both trades in every setting but the author's earlier distance rule, which excludes it, and the first coding, which adds

Table 3: Chance of the documentary match among the survivors, for the 30 corners that could carry it. "Strict": clothier and licensed premises attested; "inclusive": a partial licensed match counted; "upper": every corner not excluded by a named trade counted. Chance: probability that at least one survivor carries a match when the matching corners are placed at random. Bayes factor: H1 (the scene shows one of the survivors) against H0 (no real corner), for q from 0.5 to 1, r integrated over its Beta posterior (Jeffreys prior). P(candidate): probability, under H1 at $q = 0.8$, that the corner is Jamaica × Howard NE. Upper block: the relations of H4–H5 in full (no lane; the clothier has an address on X). Lower block: the first coding (lanes kept; a clothier anywhere in the corner premises). The full grid of 36 variants (relations, population, coding, handedness, prior) is in `data/chance_multiverse.csv`. Generated by the companion code.

Handedness	Coding	Survivors	Matching survivors	Matching corners	Chance	Bayes factor	P(candidate)
Relations of H4–H5 in full (principal)							
kept	strict	8	1	3 of 30	62%	1.2–1.5	0.86
kept	inclusive	8	2	5 of 30	82%	1.3–1.7	0.44
kept	upper	8	3	13 of 30	100%	0.9–1.0	0.25
dropped	strict	14	2	3 of 30	86%	1.3–1.7	0.44
dropped	inclusive	14	3	5 of 30	97%	1.2–1.4	0.29
dropped	upper	14	5	13 of 30	100%	0.9–1.0	0.15
First coding: lanes kept, clothier anywhere at the corner							
kept	strict	10	2	4 of 30	82%	1.3–1.7	0.44
kept	inclusive	10	3	6 of 30	93%	1.3–1.6	0.29
kept	upper	10	4	14 of 30	100%	0.9–1.0	0.19
dropped	strict	17	3	4 of 30	97%	1.2–1.5	0.29
dropped	inclusive	17	4	6 of 30	100%	1.1–1.3	0.21
dropped	upper	17	6	14 of 30	100%	0.8–1.0	0.12

Adam's Court Lane SE. Across the 36 variants of the data supplement (Steegen et al., 2016), the chance of a match among the survivors lies between 60% and 100%, and Jamaica and Howard NE is the only matching survivor in 11 of them.

Table 4: Corners surviving the geometric step, and those with both trades, under other settings (generated by the companion code).

Geometric setting	Corners	With both trades	Jamaica × Howard NE kept
every frontage point, handedness kept	8	1	yes
every frontage point, no handedness	14	2	yes
first coding: lanes kept, clothier anywhere at the corner	10	2	yes
first coding, no handedness	17	3	yes
1857 openings only, first coding (version 1.4 without its width-ratio filter)	7	1	yes
1857 openings only, width ratio 1.5–3, first coding (version 1.4 as published)	5	1	yes
1857 openings only, no handedness	10	1	yes
width ratio 1.5–3 (used up to version 1.4)	4	1	yes
angle $\geq 10°$	9	1	yes
angle $\geq 25°$	8	1	yes
widths: Y +0.7 m, X −0.7 m	8	1	yes
widths: Y −0.7 m, X +0.7 m	8	1	yes
visibility and angle measured on the plan	9	1	yes
distance $D \leq 20.4$ m (author's earlier rule)	4	0	no

5 Limits

The drawn proportions are not met: the author reads the watchers at four to six adult heights, nearer than any admissible watching point at Jamaica and Howard NE (23 m). Lefèvre notes that comics space is composed anew in each panel rather than recorded from a stable place (Lefèvre, 2008, p. 160); that a page shortens depth to keep figures and buildings in one frame is our inference. The handedness rests on an inked panel marked as a redrawing, whose pencil draft is mirrored, and on the view from the bar. Reversing the orientation at Jamaica and Howard NE, with the watchers across Howard Street, gives no point of the south frontage of Howard Street from which both faces are seen. A composite set remains possible: the sign and the corner are not in one frame, and the corner panel is marked as a rerun; the panels Rosa took from the 1963 and 1964 stories show no street corner. The directory evidence for every corner except Jamaica and Howard NE and Jamaica and Argyle SW was read in the OCR of one volume; for those two, the 1877–78 lines were checked on the page images, and the candidate is followed through fourteen other volumes in the OCR only. Unequal checking is likely to flatter the two matches, although OCR reading can also create a false match. The census places watchers only on a

frontage: if they could stand on the quay or the approach to Glasgow Bridge, the later Paisley's corner, which carries the pair, would probably pass the geometry as well. Only the corners whose facing frontage is digitised are tested, the frontages are digitised to about a metre, and the openings date from 1857. The window, the codebook, the decision to drop the width-ratio filter and the two requirements added to the first coding were all fixed after the candidate was known, the last two after a corner the panels contradict had come out; the data supplement reports every variant. No panel is reproduced.

6 A dime, a street corner, and the chance of a match

A careful match exists. At the north-east corner of Jamaica Street and Howard Street, the 1857 plan gives a frontage across Jamaica Street from which both faces of the corner are seen with Howard Street on the right, and the 1877–78 directory gives a clothier, Hugh Morrison, fronting Howard Street, and a spirit dealer, J. B. Turner, across it; both lines were checked on the page images. With the handedness of the inked view, which the view from the bar confirms, it is the only corner of the window that fits both the drawing and the trades. The match is nonetheless unremarkable. Clothiers and drinking places were common at the foot of Jamaica Street: the pair occurs at 3 of the 30 corners, among them the later Paisley's corner, which the sign points to and which fails only the geometry, and a match among the survivors would arise by chance 62% of the time. The evidence raises the odds that Rosa drew a real corner of this window by 1.2–1.5, and even a faithful drawing of a real corner would be singled out only 39% of the time. Version 1.4 called this corner the probable topographic basis of the scene; that conclusion rested on a selection of facades, on the openings recorded in 1857 and on not asking how often a match arises by chance, and it is withdrawn. If Rosa drew a real corner of this window, it was most probably this one; whether he did, only he can say. Still open: the OCR-only rows of the directory table on the page images, the provisional panel references, and the 1877–78 valuation roll (National Records of Scotland, n.d.; ScotlandsPeople, 2026).

Data and code availability

Survey files, the directory table for every orientation with its codebook, the transcribed directory lines and book-page concordance, the census, the chance analysis and the full grid of variants, generated tables and figure scripts are in `https://github.com/mlabarrere/a-street-corner-for-a-dime`; archived on Zenodo, concept DOI 10.5281/zenodo.24170392. The command `make all` regenerates tables, figures and paper; `make test` checks the counts and the chance figures, and that every generated table and data file is byte-identical to what the code writes.

Generative AI use statement

The author, working alone and without funding, used generative AI to read sources and to write code and text faster. Claude Opus 5.5 (Anthropic), in November 2026, made the first reading of the 1877–78 directory OCR for every corner of the window, coded the directory table, checked the lines for Jamaica and Argyle SW and the later Paisley's corner on the page images (the crops were shown to the author), wrote the census, chance-analysis and figure code with the libraries named in the data supplement, and drafted the text of this version, including the abstract and the conclusion. ChatGPT and Codex (OpenAI; versions not recorded) were used for earlier versions; the width-ratio band used as a filter up to version 1.4 came from a single exploratory ChatGPT reading of the panels, and five readings of the panels by one model are no longer used as evidence. The author chose the question and the window, supplied and read the panels, decided which drawn relations to apply, compared the directory lines for Jamaica and Howard NE with the page images, and approved this version. No model output is treated as archival evidence. Conversation logs are available on request.

Licences

Original text, tables and plan diagrams: CC BY 4.0. Source code: MIT. Excluded: Figure 1, a schematic after Disney panels; the directory transcriptions, which follow the National Library of Scotland digitisation (CC BY-NC-SA 2.5 Scotland); third-party map information, which keeps its stated attribution and re-use conditions.

Acknowledgements

Figures 2 and 3 are redrawn from the Ordnance Survey town plans in the georeferenced layers of the National Library of Scotland, under the Library's stated CC-BY (NLS) re-use terms.

References

Mathieu Aubry, Bryan C. Russell, and Josef Sivic. Painting-to-3D model alignment via discriminative visual elements. *ACM Transactions on Graphics*, 33(2):14:1–14:14, 2014. doi: 10.1145/2591009.

M. L. Benedikt. To take hold of space: Isovists and isovist fields. *Environment and Planning B: Planning and Design*, 6(1):47–65, 1979. doi: 10.1068/b060047.

Simon Broadbent. Simulating the ley hunter. *Journal of the Royal Statistical Society, Series A*, 143(2):109–140, 1980.

Canmore (Historic Environment Scotland). Glasgow, 72 Jamaica Street, Paisley's Warehouse. Canmore ID 161875 (NS56SE 438), `https://canmore.org.uk/site/161875`, n.d. Accessed 12 November 2026.

Sébastien Caquard. Cartography I: Mapping narrative cartography. *Progress in Human Geography*, 37(1):135–144, 2013.

Rémi Cura, Bertrand Dumenieu, Nathalie Abadie, Benoit Costes, Julien Perret, and Maurizio Gribaudi. Historical collaborative geocoding. *ISPRS International Journal of Geo-Information*, 7(7):262, 2018. doi: 10.3390/ijgi7070262. Preprint arXiv:1703.07138.

Jason Dittmer. Comic book visualities: A methodological manifesto on geography, montage and narration. *Transactions of the Institute of British Geographers*, 35(2):222–236, 2010. doi: 10.1111/j.1475-5661.2009.00376.x.

Jindřich Frajer and Petr Šimáček. Localisation of the painter's canvas: Landscape paintings from the Iron Mountains (Czech Republic). *Journal of Maps*, 15(3):66–74, 2019. doi: 10.1080/17445647.2018.1563570.

Andrew Gelman and Eric Loken. The statistical crisis in science. *American Scientist*, 102(6):460–465, 2014.

Grace's Guide. Paisleys. `https://www.gracesguide.co.uk/Paisleys`, n.d. Paisleys Limited, 1911: 82–96 Jamaica Street and 2–12 Broomielaw. Accessed 13 November 2026.

Ian N. Gregory and Paul S. Ell. *Historical GIS: Technologies, Methodologies and Scholarship*. Cambridge University Press, Cambridge, 2007. doi: 10.1017/CBO9780511493645.

Frans Grijzenhout. *Vermeer's Little Street: A View of the Penspoort in Delft*. Rijksmuseum, Amsterdam, 2015. Translated by Lynne Richards.

Sheila Hones. *Literary Geographies: Narrative Space in* Let The Great World Spin. Palgrave Macmillan, New York, 2014.

Inducks. Story codes D 91249 and D 91308. `https://inducks.org`, n.d.

Robert E. Kass and Adrian E. Raftery. Bayes factors. *Journal of the American Statistical Association*, 90(430):773–795, 1995. doi: 10.1080/01621459.1995.10476572.

Eric Laurier. The graphic transcript: Poaching comic book grammar for inscribing the visual, spatial and temporal aspects of action. *Geography Compass*, 8(4):235–248, 2014.

Pascal Lefèvre. The construction of space in comics. In Jeet Heer and Kent Worcester, editors, *A Comics Studies Reader*, pages 157–162. University Press of Mississippi, 2008. doi: 10.2307/j.ctt2tvd9s.21. Reprinted from *Image & Narrative* 16 (2006).

National Records of Scotland. Valuation Rolls: Glasgow Burgh, VR102 (1855–1975). NRS online catalogue; VR102/223–226 (1875–76, Glasgow), VR102/232 (index of streets, 1875), VR102/233–235 (1876–77), VR102/242–245 (1877–78), n.d.

Donald W. Olson. *Celestial Sleuth: Using Astronomy to Solve Mysteries in Art, History and Literature*. Springer, New York, 2014. doi: 10.1007/978-1-4614-8403-5.

Ordnance Survey. Town plan of Glasgow, 1:500, surveyed 1857–58, published 1859, sheets Lanarkshire VI.10.15 and VI.10.20. National Library of Scotland, georeferenced layer 80, `https://maps.nls.uk/townplans/glasgow_1.html`, 1859. Licence CC-BY (NLS).

Ordnance Survey. Town plan of Glasgow, 1:500, surveyed 1892–94, published 1894–95. National Library of Scotland, georeferenced layer 81, `https://maps.nls.uk/townplans/glasgow_2.html`, 1895. Licence CC-BY (NLS).

Nick Ottens. The times of Scrooge McDuck: The Last of the Clan McDuck. Never Was magazine, 9 April 2020, `https://neverwasmag.com/2020/04/the-times-of-scrooge-mcduck-the-last-of-the-clan-mcduck/`, 2020a. Accessed 13 November 2026.

Nick Ottens. The times of Scrooge McDuck: Of Ducks and Dimes and Destinies. Never Was magazine, 12 April 2020, `https://neverwasmag.com/2020/04/the-times-of-scrooge-mcduck-of-ducks-and-dimes-and-destinies/`, 2020b. Review; places the story in and around Jamaica Street from the printed plate, notes that Paisley's was a real outfitter, argues that the visitor's arrival street cannot be Jamaica Street because of the 1872 tramline and asks readers to name that street; the title is printed there as *Of Ducks and Dimes and Destinies*. Accessed 13 November 2026.

Giada Peterle. Comic book cartographies: A cartocentred reading of *City of Glass*, the graphic novel. *cultural geographies*, 24(1):43–68, 2017. doi: 10.1177/1474474016643972.

Barbara Piatti, Hans Rudolf Bär, Anne-Kathrin Reuschel, Lorenz Hurni, and William Cartwright. Mapping literature: Towards a geography of fiction. In William Cartwright, Georg Gartner, and Antje Lehn, editors, *Cartography and Art*, pages 177–192. Springer, Berlin, 2009. doi: 10.1007/978-3-540-68569-2_15.

Brandon Plewe. The nature of uncertainty in historical geographic information. *Transactions in GIS*, 6(4):431–456, 2002. doi: 10.1111/1467-9671.00121.

Post Office. Post-Office Annual Glasgow Directory. National Library of Scotland digitisation on Internet Archive, identifiers `postofficeannual<yy><yy>gla` (e.g. `https://archive.org/details/postofficeannual187778gla` for 1877–78), 1860–1906. Volumes 1860–61, 1865–66, 1870–71, 1876–77 to 1881–82, 1885–86, 1890–91 to 1892–93, 1895–96, 1905–06 read in OCR; the 1877–78 lines marked † in `data/directory_lines.md` checked on the page images. Digitisation published under CC BY-NC-SA 2.5 Scotland. Accessed 12 and 13 November 2026.

RailScot. Glasgow St Enoch. `https://railscot.co.uk/locations/G/Glasgow_St_Enoch`, n.d. Opened 17 October 1876 on the City of Glasgow Union Railway. Accessed 13 November 2026.

Stijn Reijnders. *Places of the Imagination: Media, Tourism, Culture*. Ashgate, Farnham, 2011.

Don Rosa. Pencil layouts for *The Last of the Clan McDuck*, pages 6–7. Scans of the artist's pencil pages, circulated online with his copyright notice, 1992. Consulted November 2026; not reproduced.

Don Rosa. *La Grande épopée de Picsou – Intégrale Don Rosa, t. 1: La Jeunesse de Picsou 1/2*. Glénat, Grenoble, 2012. French edition; *Le Dernier du clan McPicsou* pp. 11–25.

Don Rosa. *La Grande épopée de Picsou – Intégrale Don Rosa, t. 2: La Jeunesse de Picsou 2/2*. Glénat, Grenoble, 2013. French edition; author's note pp. 4–6, *Canards, cents et destinées !* pp. 9–23, commentary pp. 24–26.

Don Rosa. *The Don Rosa Library, Vol. 4: The Last of the Clan McDuck*. Fantagraphics Books, Seattle, 2015. Contains *Of Ducks, Dimes and Destinies* (Inducks D 91249, pp. 9–23) and *The Last of the Clan McDuck* (D 91308, pp. 25–39), with the author's commentaries.

Angharad Saunders. Literary geography: Reforging the connections. *Progress in Human Geography*, 34(4):436–452, 2010.

ScotlandsPeople. Valuation rolls, 1855–1940 (decennial years). `https://www.scotlandspeople.gov.uk/guides/valuation-rolls`, 2026. Only the 1875–76 roll is online for the 1870s; 2 credits per image. Accessed 9 November 2026.

Gareth Shaw. Directories as sources in urban history: A review of British and Canadian material. *Urban History Yearbook*, 11:36–44, 1984. doi: 10.1017/S0963926800006908.

Sara Steegen, Francis Tuerlinckx, Andrew Gelman, and Wolf Vanpaemel. Increasing transparency through a multiverse analysis. *Perspectives on Psychological Science*, 11(5):702–712, 2016. doi: 10.1177/1745691616658637.

Nerys Tunnicliffe. Glasgow Central Station – times past. Glasgow Life, stories and blogs from the Mitchell Library, 26 June 2026, `https://www.glasgowlife.org.uk/libraries/family-history/stories-and-blogs-from-the-mitchell/times-past-blogs/glasgow-central-station-times-past`, 2026. Accessed 13 November 2026.

Motti Zohar and Ilan Shimshoni. GIScience integrated with computer vision for the examination of old engravings and drawings. *International Journal of Geographical Information Science*, 35(9):1703–1724, 2021. doi: 10.1080/13658816.2021.1874957.